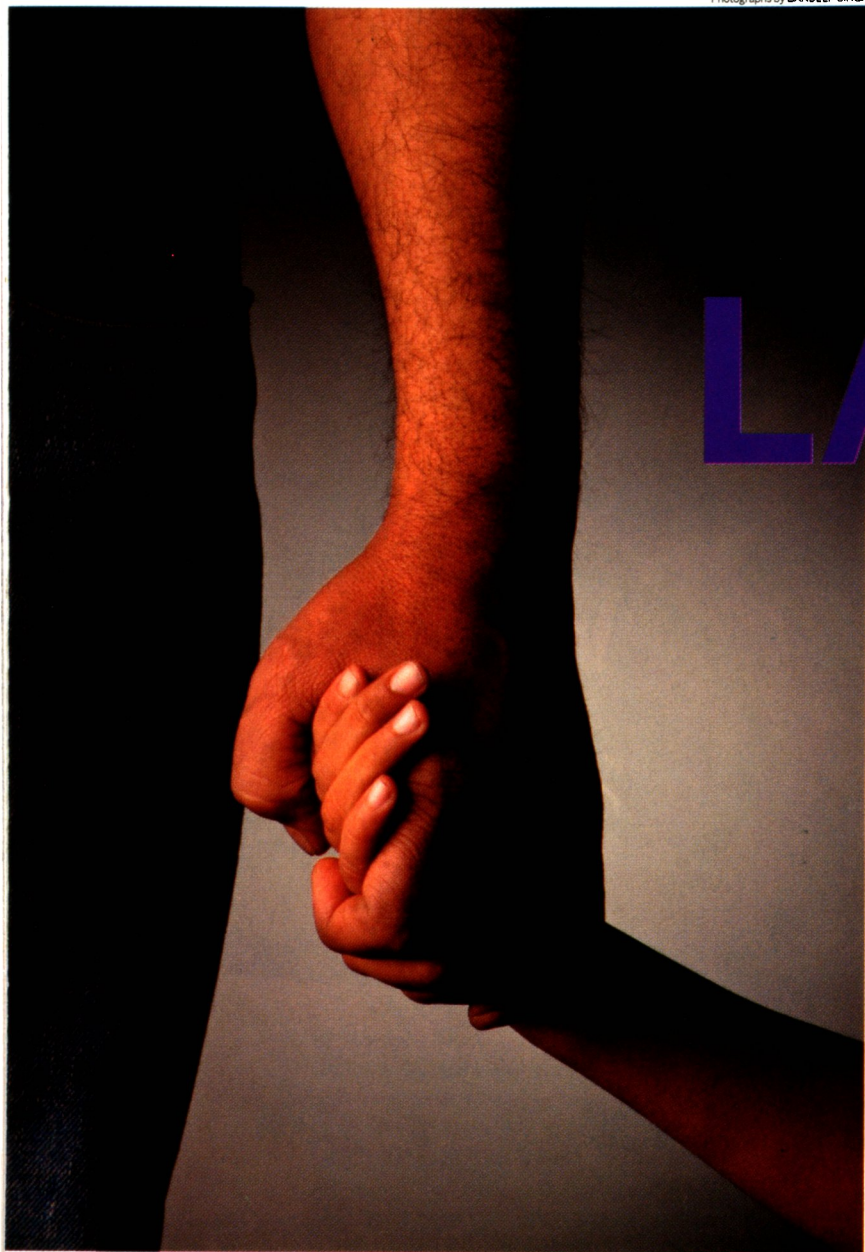


Photographs by BANDEEP SINGH



# Silence of the LAMBS

Incest and other forms of sexual abuse of a child are far more common than we assume. But it is also a shame that dares not speak its name.

By Mike Lew

Throughout history and everywhere in the world, societies have struggled with the issue of incest. I know of no society that does not prohibit sexual activity between family members, although the definition of "relative" varies. In all the cultures I am aware of, sexual activity between parent and child and between siblings is viewed as incestuous and prohibited. Most societies extend the prohibition to other categories of relatives in the extended family or clan.

There is no need to prohibit something that doesn't exist. Incest taboos exist everywhere because every culture recognises the need to protect children from incestuous abuse. Therapists and counsellors who specialise in sexual abuse treatment expand the concept of incest beyond the traditional definition of sexual activity between close relatives. Professionals and support organisations of incest survivors share a broader working definition: incest is a violation of a position of trust, power and protection. Sex between close blood relatives is one part of this larger, more inclusive view of incest.

Incest differs from other forms of sexual abuse, as here the perpetrator is assumed to stand in a protective role to the victim. For this to be a traumatic experience, it is not necessary that the "parenting" figure should be a family member.

Have you ever had sex with a blood relation?

YES 2

NO 97

But, I want to 1

Male 3, Female 1

Male 96, Female 97

Male 1, Female 1

Rest don't know/can't say. All figures in per cent

Was your sexual encounter with the blood relation consensual?

YES 64

NO, I WAS FORCED 36

Male 69, Female 54

Male 31, Female 46

For 116 respondents of the total of 5,353 who had experienced incest.

All figures in per cent